Wildlife lodges craft personalised immersive journeys for eco-conscious guests, improved airports and roads in the Northeast have made once remote Buddhist monasteries more accessible, while wellness centres effortlessly blend ancient healing traditions with modern diagnostics.

According to Anil Chadha, Managing Director of ITC Hotels, today's luxury travellers question not where they can go but rather what they can take back in terms of experiences. "That shift of immersing oneself in the local ethos, be it through cultural and traditional experiences of the region or culinary trails and rituals, is redefining travel in India."

The timing too, is particularly favourable for domestic tourism. A volatile geopolitical environment, flight disruptions across key international corridors, increasingly lengthy visa processing times and a weakening rupee have all made overseas travel more complicated. For many affluent Indians, the calculation has subtly shifted. Why spend weeks planning a European itinerary when a vacation in India can deliver a similarly immersive escape? The result is a growing appetite for destinations that offer both discovery and convenience as travellers venture beyond traditional luxury circuits.

SACRED JOURNEYS

"Pilgrimage tourism is arguably one of India's most powerful and fastest-transforming travel segments, evolving from a largely faith-driven segment into a broader tourism and infrastructure-led development story," says Akash Datta, Managing Director (South Asia), HVS Anarock. "Spiritual tourism has moved into the mainstream and is now steady year-round, cutting across age groups," points out Chadha of ITC Hotels.

According to MakeMyTrip's Pilgrimage Travel Trends 2024-25 report, hotel bookings across 56 religious destinations rose 19% year-on-year, while premium accommodation bookings priced above ₹10,000 a night grew 23%, underscoring a willingness among travellers to spend more on comfort. "Millennials account for nearly 6 in 10 pilgrimage travellers in FY26, mirroring their share of overall leisure travel. Almost 1 in 6 pilgrims is now Gen Z. Boomers' participation is over 50% higher than their share of general leisure travel. Together, these numbers paint a picture of a segment that is younger, broader, and more deeply rooted in Indian life," says Rajesh Magow, Co-Founder and Group CEO, MakeMyTrip. What is driving the shift is not simply faith, but the convergence of spirituality with wellness, culture and leisure.



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